16 People of India

Topics covered

- Food
- Festivals
- Languages
- Population
- Unity in Diversity

Fill the blanks:

The state where you live: .....

The main foods that people eat in your state: .....

The main festivals of your state: .....

The languages spoken in your state: .....

India is a large and very **diverse** country. It has a lot of variety and differences in several areas. People eat different foods, celebrate various festivals and speak several languages. There are also some things that **unite** (join together) the Indian people.

FOOD

The geography of a region influences the food that people eat. The **staple** (main) food of people is whatever grows in their region. Wheat grows in north India, so the staple food here is wheat, which is eaten as *rotis, parathas* or *puris*. In the east and south, rice is an important crop. Here the staple food is rice. In parts of India where there is less rainfall, various millets grow. Their small grains are ground into flour and used to make *rotis* of different kinds. There are other foods that many Indians eat. *Daals* are eaten in almost the entire country and prepared in many different ways. In north-east India, where a lot of bamboo grows, tender bamboo shoots are part of the diet of the people. Most Indians flavour their food with spices

like yellow turmeric and chillies. Many people also use onions and ginger to flavour their food.

Small grains of millets

Tender bamboo shoots are used in many food preparations in north-east India.

A recent study has found that in some parts of India—such as the states of north-east India, West Bengal and Kerala—people are largely non-vegetarian. In other states, like Haryana and Rajasthan, the people are mostly vegetarian.

All these foods are cooked in hundreds of different ways all over India. Indian food is very diverse.

Discuss

Why is there so much diversity in the foods that Indian people eat?

Did you Know?

The coastal states of west India and West Bengal are fish-eating states. Coastal states are near the sea so people eat sea fish (saltwater fish). In West Bengal people eat fish from the many rivers and ponds here (sweet water fish).

FESTIVALS

'Festival' means a time of celebration. There is a reason and meaning for every festival.

You learnt earlier about the many different festivals of India. Some festivals are linked to an important event, like the **harvest** festivals of India. Many people in India are farmers, so harvest time, when they cut their ripe crops, is very important. Baisakhi (Punjab), Pongal (Tamil Nadu) and Bihu (Assam) are all harvest festivals.

A decorated pot for Pongal, in which the special Pongal rice and milk is cooked

Think and answer

Why do people in the cities also celebrate harvest festivals?

Most festivals in India are religious festivals. India is a country of many different religions and each has different festivals. Some of the best-known religious festivals are Diwali, Eid and Christmas. These are celebrated almost all over India by people of the different religions. There are also religious festivals that are mainly celebrated in a particular region or state. Some well-known ones are Ganesh Chaturthi (Maharashtra), Chhat Puja (Bihar), Gurpurab (Punjab) and Durga Puja (West Bengal).

Discuss

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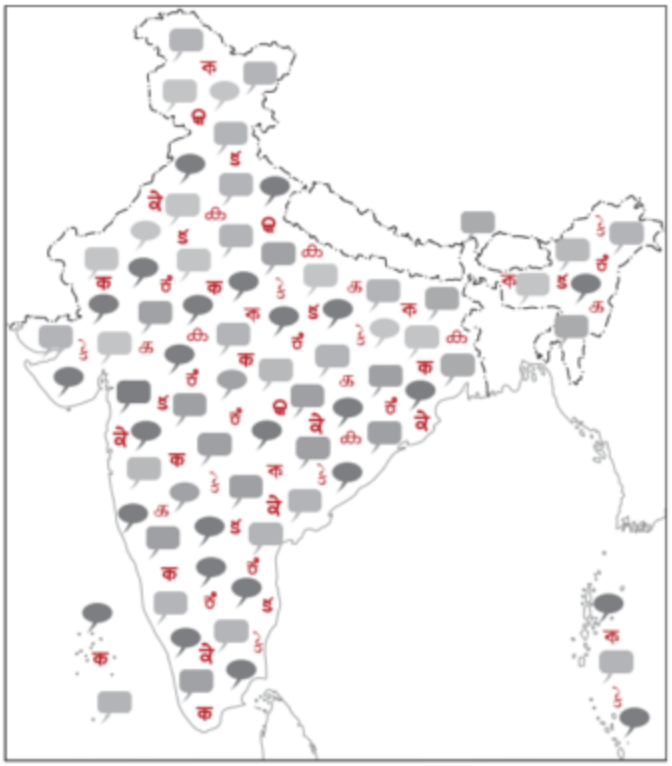
- How do you and your friends celebrate various festivals?
- Bring some festival items to show and talk about in class—like Diwali lamps or Christmas decorations.

LANGUAGES

Indians speak many different languages. The Constitution of India specially mentions 22 languages—some are Hindi, Bengali, Tamil and Marathi. However, India actually has about 800 languages! Some are spoken by millions of people but others are spoken by only a few thousand people.

Hindi is understood and spoken in large parts of the country. It is the official language of India. This means it is used by governments for their work. Because the British ruled India for several centuries, English is spoken in many parts of India. It is used in many offices and institutions. People also learn it because it helps them to communicate with people from other parts of the world.

Many Indians speak more than one language. This makes it easy for them to communicate with people from another state or region.



Many different languages are spoken in India.

Did you Know?

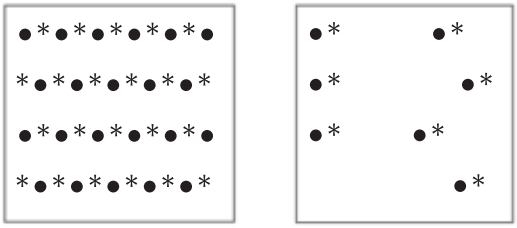
The state with the most languages is Arunachal Pradesh. It has 30-50 main languages and several others that are spoken in particular regions.

POPULATION

Population means all the people in a particular area. India has a very large population. There are about 1 billion 324 million (1,324,000,000) people in India! This number is growing all the time.

Though India has a large population, it is not the same in all parts of the country. It is very dense in some places and less **dense** in others. Dense means a lot of people or things in a space.

Which square has a higher density of dots?



Like these squares, some parts of India have a higher density of population than others. This is linked to the geography of the country.

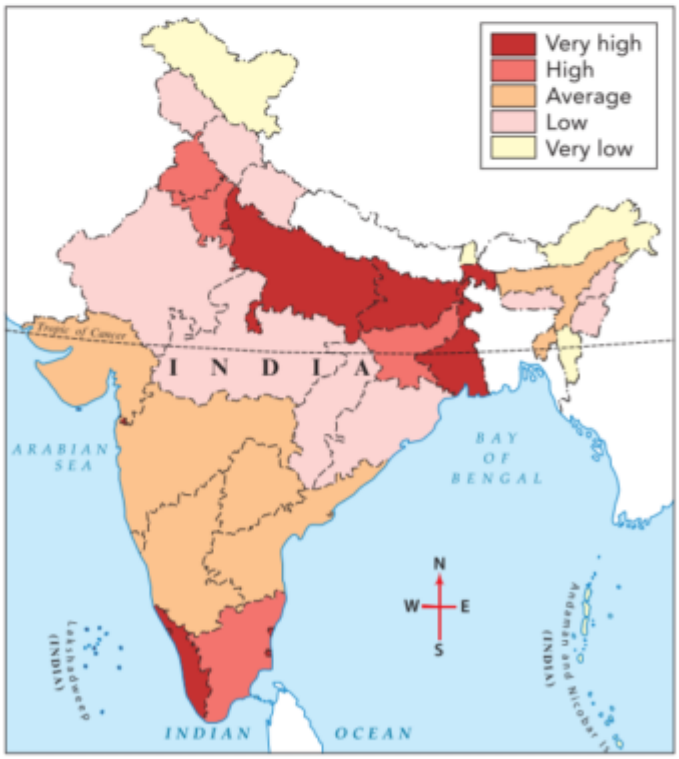
TP Compare the two maps and answer these questions:

1. Which natural regions have a low density of population?

   .....

2. Which natural regions have a very high density of population?

   .....



Population density of India

Natural regions of India

The mountain regions and the desert area have a low density of population. Parts of central India also have a low density. This is because there are thick forests here.

Think and answer

TP Why do the mountains, the desert and forested areas have a low density of population?

India's population is highest in the plains and coastal plains where it is easy to grow good crops, so food is easily available.

UNITY IN DIVERSITY

Did you Know?

Out of India's total population, about one third are children of 14 years or less!

The people of India, their foods, festivals and languages—all these make India a very diverse country. However, there are also things that unite the people of India:

- The national symbols like the Indian flag and the national anthem
- The Constitution of India which was written in the early years of our Independence. It unites the Indian people because it has rules and laws that are the same for *all* Indians. Two examples of such laws are:
  - *all* Indians are equal—whether they are rich or poor, men or women, or of any religion
  - *all* Indians who are over the age of 18 and have registered as voters can vote in elections.

In spite of the diversity in so many different areas, the large population of India is united as Indians.

Values and Life Skills

How should we behave when we meet other Indians who are different from us in some way?

REMEMBER

1. India is a very big and diverse country.
2. Though there are differences and variety in the food, festivals and languages of the Indian people, there are many similarities too.
3. In spite of diversity, the national symbols and the Constitution of India unite the people of India.

NEW WORDS

Diverse	with a lot of variety; very different
Unite	to join together
Staple	a large or important part of something, like food or diet
Harvest	the time when crops are cut and gathered
Population	all the people in a particular area
Dense	containing a lot of people, things, plants, etc. in an area

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

1. ..... are eaten almost all over India.
2. Every ..... is celebrated for a particular reason.
3. ..... languages are specially mentioned in the Indian Constitution.
4. India's ..... density is not the same all over the country.
5. Two national symbols of India are ..... and .....

B. Match the following.

A	B
1. staple	a. with a lot of variety; very different
2. dense	b. all the people in a particular area
3. diverse	c. the time of cutting and gathering the crops
4. population	d. containing a lot of people, things, or plants in an area
5. harvest	e. a large or important part of food or diet

C. Write true or false.

Correct the false sentences in your notebook.

1. The staple foods eaten in India are rice, wheat or millets.
2. Most festivals in India are religious festivals.
3. There are about 500 languages in India.
4. India's population is more than 2 billion.
5. The Constitution of India applies to all Indians.

D. Choose the correct answer.

1. Popular spices used in Indian food are **bamboo shoots**/**turmeric and chillies**.
2. Diwali, Eid and Christmas are **harvest**/**religious** festivals.
3. **English**/**Hindi** is the official language of India.
4. The population of India is **the same all over the country**/**less in some parts and more in other parts**.
5. The Indian Constitution says that **all**/**only some** Indians are equal.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. Name two parts of India where people are mostly (a) vegetarian and (b) non-vegetarian.
2. What does festival mean? Name three harvest festivals.
3. Give two reasons why English is one of the languages in India.
4. Name one region each in India with low and very high density of population.
5. Explain why the Constitution unites India.
6. Give one example of a law that applies to all Indians.

THINGS TO DO

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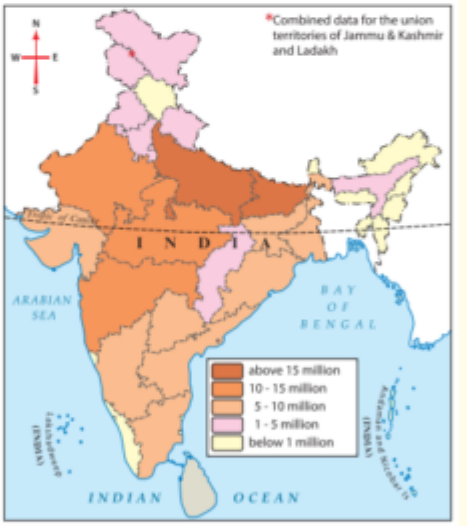
A. Map study

The map shows the child population in Indian states. In the dark red states, the population is above 15 million. In the yellow states it is below 1 million.

1. With the help of the earlier maps in the book, find out which the dark red and yellow states are.
2. How will this affect the future population in these states?



B. On your own

See how India's population is growing – go to http://www.poodwaddle.com/worldclock/pop4/ (accessed on 7 November 2017)

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C. In a group

Have a 'States of India' exhibition!

Each group should choose a state and add aspects of the life of people, like:

- A menu with popular foods of the state including the staple food: Display the menu and recipes.
- A festival: Find out why and how it is celebrated. Make a festival display.

WEBLINK

Population density: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bbs-gwmAuGw (accessed on 27 July 2017)